

Urgent Action Needed on Climate Change



Deepak Sood
Secretary General ASSOCHAM

Over the last few months, we have already seen extreme weather playing out across the country. Cyclone Remal left the Northeast battered in May and intense heat waves with temperatures soaring to 52 degrees were recorded in parts of the country a few days later.

With extreme climate conditions increasing in frequency and intensity, the new Government will perforce have to take action on protecting our environment and ensuring we adopt sustainable lifestyles even as we chase developmental goals.

Come monsoons, we are also likely to see either a record decline or surplus rainfall leading to situations like depleting groundwater levels or rise in sea levels. These dramatic changes will have equally-intense reactions – melting glaciers, the Himalayan ranges losing their snow covers impacting the flowing patterns of major rivers, salt water intrusion into coastal areas

degrading groundwater quality. India has a shoreline that covers 17,000 kilometres and our coastal zones are densely populated with approximately 14% of the population concentrated in coastal districts, amounting to approximately 200 million people.

With Indus and the Ganges-Brahmaputra-Meghna Basins being major trans boundary rivers, changes in their flow pattern are likely to trigger cross-border conflicts and an possible influx of climate refugees. Along with human migration, we are likely to see changes in migration patterns of wild animals and a dwindling of species as well.

Surplus and untimely rain or drought situations will result in both food and water security issues impacting major industries, including agriculture – the mainstay of our economy. Equally crippling will be energy security challenges since India is largely dependent on hydro and thermal energy. With rising demand from industry, agriculture, a growing population and rising standards of living, cost of energy will rise impacting availability and affordability. With basics becoming pricier, malnutrition and health concerns, especially among the poor, will rise. Heat waves will lead to deaths and weather extremes will lead to outbreak of diseases- old and new.

Urgent interventions

Forests cover 25 % of India and 20% of these forests are primary, making them some of the richest in terms of biodiversity. Ways to preserve these, increase the area under forests, prevent forest fires and increase mangrove plantations to preserve the coastline and reduce the impact of coastal storms and tsunamis will be in focus. India's national forest policy, aims for trees

on 33% of the country's area. The India Development Review recommends that it is important to simultaneously revive ecosystems and ensure local people and tribes are benefitted too.

For the farming sector, the changing weather patterns need the Government to help farmers deal with the challenges of climate change by helping them diversify their cropping patterns, access the latest agricultural know-how, use digital technologies to learn about crop advisories, improve soil and water management, and develop both farm and non-farm enterprises.

The Government's Atal Bhujal Yojana aims sustainable ground water management. This program is under implementation in select districts across seven states. The need for better ground water management could benefit a lot more districts and many more states.

India has the advantage of being in the forefront of technological advancements. This can be mainstreamed into actual benefits for communities via forecasting, planning and strengthening response and relief operations in extreme weather conditions.

India also has an estimated 104 million indigenous people which account for 8.6% of the population. There are 705 officially recognized ethnic groups which are very adept at building sustainable ecosystems using traditional conservation methods. If the Government could collate this knowledge and promote its usage, it would greatly help conserve resources, improve agricultural production and even revive long-forgotten native flora and fauna. By combining native wisdom with the latest technology, India could find some simple and innovative solutions.